

Carne Asada Picada

Diced shoulder clod · frozen plain · griddle chop-and-sear · the taco brings the brightness, heat & salt

PORTION	DICE	FREEZER	SEAR
450 g bags	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " cross-grain	3+ months	IR 450–500°F

WHAT YOU NEED

the bag is just beef — everything else is cook-day

Beef shoulder clod diced $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", across the grain	the star
Beef tallow or neutral oil — to sear	to coat
Maggi light griddle glaze (umami)	a splash
Lime + flaky salt at the taco	to finish
White onion + cilantro raw, chopped — at the taco	to finish
Corn tortillas double-stacked, warm	2 per taco

PHASE 1 BUTCHER & FREEZE

freeze plain — no marinade (no acid-mush; a dry surface sears, not steams)

- Dice:** trim the clod, cut $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (1–1.5 cm) cubes across the grain — cross-grain for tenderness, uniform for an even sear.
- Bag + freeze plain:** portion into quart bags (450 g), press flat, remove air, date, freeze. **Nothing in the bag** — you season at the griddle and the taco.

PHASE 3 SEAR & BUILD

ripping-hot — sear, don't steam

- Thaw + pat BONE-DRY:** fridge overnight, then dry hard — thawed beef weeps, and surface water kills the crust.
- Ripping-hot griddle** (cast iron / flat-top, IR 450–500°F), **beef tallow**. **Single layer, do NOT crowd** — crowding drops the temp and steams the beef gray.
- Chop-and-sear:** let it crust untouched, then chop/toss with two spatulas and let it re-crust — building **15–20% dark caramelized edges**. Hit it with a **light splash of Maggi** near the end — it glazes; don't drown it or it steams.
- Doneness — no thermometer** (a $\frac{1}{2}$ " cube overshoots before a probe reads). Pull at **deep-charred edges, the cube firmed but still giving, juicy/pink inside**. Pull while juicy — shoulder dice has no time to render, so overcooked = dry and tight.
- Build:** double-stacked warm tortillas → beef → **fresh lime** → **flaky salt** → raw onion + cilantro → **the salsa (p.2)**. Brightness *and* heat both land at the table.

IF IT GOES WRONG

Tough / chewy	Overcooked, or cut with the grain — pull while juicy; dice across the grain.
Gray, no char	Crowded or wet surface — single layer, pat bone-dry, recover to 450–500°F.
Tastes flat	No acid/salt in the bag, by design — that's the taco's job: lime + flaky salt + salsa.

Asada Salsa

Salsa de chile de árbol y tomatillo — grandma's: boiled tomatillo, toasted árbol, garlic, cilantro. Spicy.

YIELD	ACTIVE	HEAT	KEEPS
~2 cups (480 ml)	~25 min	Spicy	4–5 days, fridge

INGREDIENTS

five things — tomatillo, árbol, garlic, cilantro, salt

Tomatillos fresh, boiled — ~1 lb, store-bought fine	~450 g
Chiles de árbol toasted — the heat; SPICY, ~12–15 g	a handful
Garlic boiled with the tomatillos	3 cloves
Cilantro fresh, raw — leaves + stems	a handful
Salt Diamond Crystal — to taste	to taste

METHOD

boil · toast · blend · salt — no onion, no fry

- 1 Boil.** Simmer the tomatillos + garlic cloves in water until the tomatillos turn **olive-green and soft** (~8–10 min). Scoop out; **save a little of the cooking water**.
- 2 Toast the árbol.** Light toast on a comal / the Ooni edge — fragrant and bendy, **zero black** (old chiles tip bitter fast). Optional: bloom a few in a spoon of beef tallow to wake them.
- 3 Blend.** Boiled tomatillo + garlic, toasted árbol, a **handful of raw cilantro** (stems too), and salt — blend smooth, loosen with the cooking water to spoonable. **No straining** (árbol skin is thin), **no frying**.
- 4 Taste. SPICY is the target** — add árbol till it bites; salt to taste. Judge on a **built taco**, not the spoon (fat + tortilla mute it).

Heat = árbol, the only knob — a big handful of the old chiles now; a **pinch** of chiltepín later (3–5× hotter). Boiled tomatillo is committed; raw-vs-charred tomatillo + raw-vs-boiled garlic are the next dial-in (ask the aunts).